“I don't belong in church because of my past.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

A history of addiction, divorce, abortion, prison, affairs, or years away from God can make a church building feel like a courtroom. We imagine that everyone has a spotless record and that our past would be unwelcome. Sometimes this is reinforced by real experiences of being whispered about.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes to the Corinthians, “And that is what some of you were. But you were washed, you were sanctified, you were justified, in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ and by the Spirit of our God.” The Pharisees grumbled, “This man welcomes sinners and eats with them,” which was a compliment, not an insult. Jesus said of the woman who anointed His feet, “because her many sins have been forgiven, she has loved much.” Paul adds, “If anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation.” Hebrews says, “Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence.” The church is where forgiven people gather, and your past is not your identity.

> *“And that is what some of you were. But you were washed, you were sanctified, you were justified, in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ and by the Spirit of our God”*
> (1 Corinthians 6:11).

Also see

> “So the Pharisees and scribes began to grumble: ‘This man welcomes sinners and eats with them.’” (Luke 15:2).

> “Therefore I tell you, because her many sins have been forgiven, she has loved much. But he who has been forgiven little loves little” (Luke 7:47).

> “Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!” (2 Corinthians 5:17).

> “Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need” (Hebrews 4:16).

Common self-statements

- People like me do not belong.
- If they knew my past, they would ask me to leave.
- I have been too far away for too long.
- I am too damaged.
- I will bring shame on the church.
- I need to clean up first.

Common logical errors

- Labeling: Calling myself by my worst moments.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that I will be rejected.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling ashamed and concluding that I do not belong.
- Discounting the positive: Ignoring that Christ has forgiven me.

Challenging questions

- What exactly in my past do I think disqualifies me?
- Has God forgiven it, according to Scripture?
- Whom did Jesus welcome?
- What would it mean to be washed and justified?
- Who in the church might understand my story?
- What would help me take one step toward a welcoming community?

Truth summary

> Christ has washed, sanctified, and justified me. My past is forgiven, and I am a new creation. I belong in the community of forgiven people, and I can look for a church that welcomes sinners as Jesus did.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Church
- Forgiveness
- Guilt/Shame
- Born Again
- Grace

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Judgmental

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Clean — Natalie Grant
God's cleansing grace challenges the belief that shame or sin makes a person beyond restoration.

Forgiveness — Matthew West
Ask God for help releasing resentment while working through real hurt.

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I don't belong in church because of my past"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I don't belong in church because of my past." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What in my past worries me?
- ☐ What does God say about it?
- ☐ Whom did Jesus welcome?
- ☐ What church welcomes sinners?
- ☐ Who is a safe believer?
- ☐ What is my next step?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I was washed, sanctified, and justified.
- ☐ Jesus welcomes sinners.
- ☐ I am a new creation.
- ☐ Much forgiven, I love much.
- ☐ I can approach the throne of grace.
- ☐ My past is not my identity.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 1 Corinthians 6:11
  "And that is what some of you were. But you were washed, you were sanctified, you were justified, in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ and by the Spirit of our God."
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 5:17
  "Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!"
- ☐ Hebrews 4:16
  "Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Forgiven and welcome: Each week, record one moment of welcome or one truth about forgiveness.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 1 Corinthians 6:11 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I was washed and justified, so I belong.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Forgiveness" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Write your fear. State what you think would happen if people knew your past.
- ☐ Confess and receive. Bring unresolved sin to God and receive forgiveness.
- ☐ Visit a welcoming church. Look for one that talks openly about grace.
- ☐ Tell one safe person. Share your story with a mature believer.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I don't belong in church because of my past": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A step toward welcome
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I don't belong in church because of my past.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You welcome sinners. Wash me and give me courage to be among Your people. Let my past be a testimony of Your mercy and not a reason to stay away. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.